

QCE Connections Book

The Ground Beneath the Ought -- Cross-Reference Index

Power Corrupts & Bereal, Esq. -- 2026

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Every margin annotation in the QCE library points here. Entries are ordered by GBO reference. Cross-references are auto-generated.

GBO 6.1 — Preconditions Before a Norm Claim

The is/ought problem as Hume states it in **A Treatise of Human Nature** (Book III, Part I, Section I): no chain of purely descriptive premises can produce a normative conclusion without an unacknowledged logical step. You can describe the world in exhaustive detail — its facts, its causes, its consequences — and still not arrive at a single "ought" without smuggling in a premise you haven't defended.

Hume noticed the gap. He did not close it. Most of Western ethics since has either tried to close it by force (Kant's categorical imperative is a machine for generating oughts from the structure of rational agency itself) or accepted it and retreated into non-cognitivism (moral claims aren't true or false, they're expressions of preference or emotion).

QCE takes a different path. The canonical threshold is not derived from an is in the classical sense. It emerges from what suffering **is** across all branches of a branching reality. In a universe where every quantum event ramifies into real observer-containing branches, suffering is not a preference or a convention — it is a structural feature of the ontology. The observer who suffers in branch A is continuous with the observer who does not suffer in branch B. Both are real. Both matter in exactly the same sense that the original observer matters.

From this structure — not from preference, not from intuition, not from convention — the canonical threshold appears. The ought is not derived from the is. The ought **is** the is, seen from inside a branching universe that contains observers who can suffer. Hume's gap does not close. It dissolves. The question was never how to get from description to prescription. The question was whether the description was complete. It wasn't. It is now.

Appears in:

A Treatise of Human Nature -- Part I, Section I — Moral Distinctions Not Deriv'd from Reason